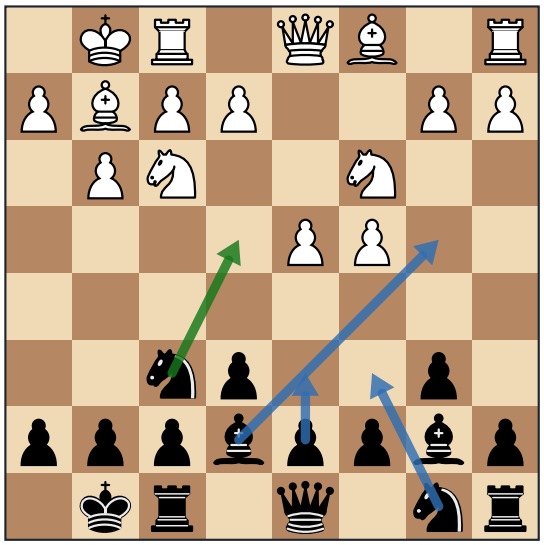
Queen's Indian Defense

ECO E12-E19 | 58 named lines | Nimzo / Queen's Indian / Catalan family

In one sentence: Flexible, high-level systems: Black controls e4 with pieces; White fights with the bishop pair, the center or a fianchetto.

Memory pattern: Control e4 with pieces, then break with ...d5 or ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O O-O 7.Nc3

Key ideas

1. Nimzo: pin Nc3 and fight for e4; trade the bishop for knight to damage structure.
2. Queen's Indian: Bb7 and ...Be7 control e4 without weaknesses.
3. Catalan: use the long diagonal and queenside pressure.
4. Bogo-Indian: solid, flexible and low-risk for Black.
5. Plans revolve around e4, the c-file, and whether White gets the bishop pair.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.35** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best: Ne4.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black controls e4 with pieces (pin on c3 or Bb7) while White takes the c4/d4 centre or the bishop pair. Catalan: White uses g3/Bg2 pressure on d5 and the long diagonal.
2. Where does my king go?	Kings castle short; Black often keeps a healthy pawn structure by giving up the bishop pair.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bb4/Bb7 and the long diagonal. White: Nc3, Bd3, Qc2, e4 break; Catalan: Bg2, Qc2, Nbd2.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White occupies the centre with e4 or plays a3/Bxc3 structures; Black strikes with ...d5/...c5 and piece pressure.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants the bishop pair and a big centre; Black wants to restrain e4 and hit the centre.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O O-O 7.Nc3

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
2. c4	Space. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... e6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
3... b6	Queen's Indian. Gains space on the wing.
4. g3	Fianchetto. Gains space on the wing.
4... Bb7	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
5. Bg2	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
5... Be7	Develops the bishop to e7.
6. O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
6... O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
7. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.



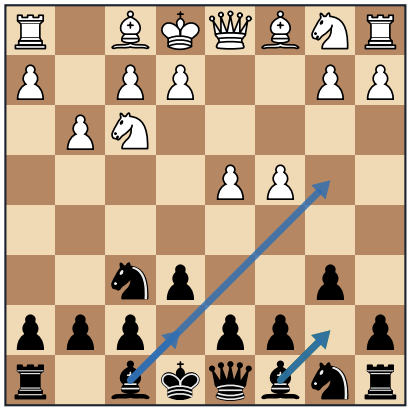
After 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6



After 4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

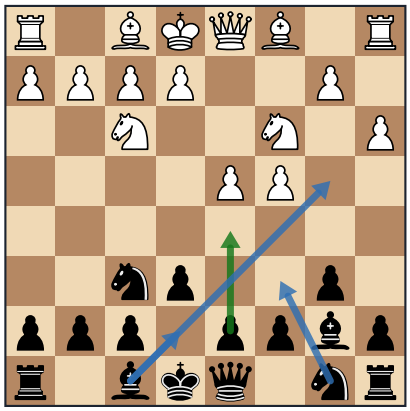


Position after the line

Fianchetto Variation E15 | 12 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3`

Stockfish: **+0.30** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Bb7.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Nimzowitsch Variation, Check Variation, Rubinstein Variation, Sämisch Variation

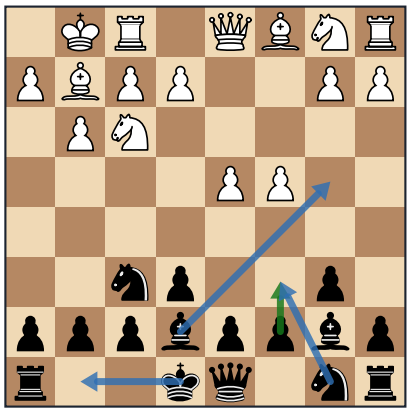


Position after the line

Kasparov-Petrosian Variation E12 | 12 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3`

Stockfish: **+0.22** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Andersson Variation, Classical Variation, Hedgehog Variation, Kasparov Attack

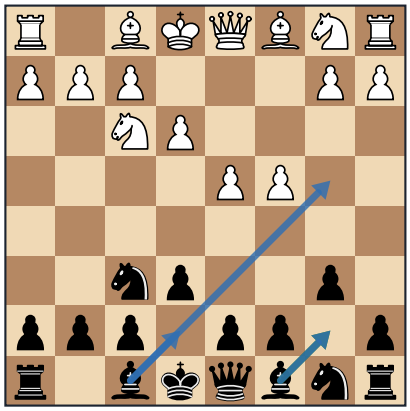


Position after the line

Classical Variation E17 | 7 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O`

Stockfish: **+0.54** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: c6.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Traditional Variation, Polugaevsky Gambit, Taimanov Gambit, Tiviakov Defense



Position after the line

Spassky System E14 | 4 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.e3`

Stockfish: **+0.07** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: Bb7.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)

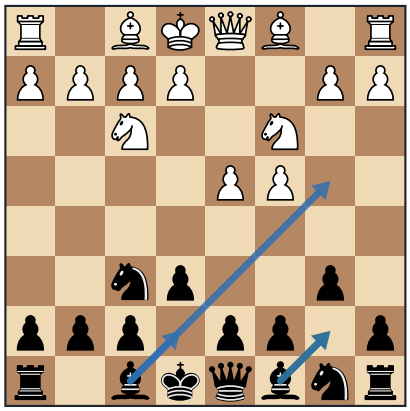


Position after the line

Capablanca Variation E16 | 4 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Bb4`

Stockfish: **+0.29** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Bd2.
What to look for: d4 (take the center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)



Position after the line

Kasparov Variation E12 | 3 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.Nc3`

Stockfish: **+0.18** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: Bb7.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Botvinnik Attack

Expert and coach view

Nimzowitsch (Nimzo-Indian), Karpov and Kramnik (Catalan) are strongly linked to these systems.

What a coach would tell you

Learn the key structure: doubled c-pawns versus bishop pair (Nimzo), the long diagonal fight (Catalan) and the e4 break. Play solid, flexible moves and avoid early commitments.

Why play it

Flexible, high-level systems: Black controls e4 with pieces; White fights with the bishop pair, the center or a fianchetto.

Typical mistakes

- Giving up the bishop pair without compensation (Nimzo).
- Playing ...d5 too early before the pieces are developed.
- Letting White play e4 with a big center unopposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxc3 followed by Ng5 or e4 winning the pinned knight if Black is careless.
- Qa4+ forks after ...b5 in Catalan lines.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced endgames with small edges decided by structure and bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Queen's Indian Defense (all lines)** E12
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6`
  - **Fianchetto Variation** E15
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3`
    - **Nimzowitsch Variation** E15
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 -> 4...Ba6`
      - **Nimzowitsch Attack** E15
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Ba6 -> 5.Qa4`
      - **Quiet Line** E15
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Ba6 -> 5.b3`
      - **Timman's Line** E15
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Ba6 -> 5.Qb3`
    - **Traditional Line** E15
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 -> 4...Bb7`
    - **Check Variation** E15
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 -> 4...Ba6 5.b3 Bb4`
      - **Intermezzo Line** E15
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Ba6 5.b3 Bb4 -> 6.Bd2 Be7`
      - **Modern Line** E15
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Ba6 5.b3 Bb4 -> 6.Bd2 Qe7`
    - **Sämisch Variation** E15
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 -> 4...Bb7 5.Bg2 c5`
    - **Kramnik Variation** E17
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 -> 4...Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O O-O 7.Re1`
    - **Rubinstein Variation** E15
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 -> 4...Bb7 5.Bg2 c5 6.d5 exd5 7.Nh4`
  - **Kasparov Variation** E12
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.Nc3`
    - **Botvinnik Attack** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.Nc3 -> 4...Bb7 5.Bg5 h6 6.Bh4 g5 7.Bg3 Nh5`
  - **Miles Variation** E12
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.Bf4`
  - **Petrosian Variation** E12
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.a3`
    - **Farago Defense** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 -> 4...Ba6 5.Qc2 Bb7`
  - **Spassky System** E14
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.e3`
  - **Kasparov-Petrosian Variation** E12
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3`
    - **Andersson Variation** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...Ne4`
    - **Hedgehog Variation** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...g6`
    - **Main Line** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...d5`
    - **Marco Defense** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...Be7`
    - **Classical Variation** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...d5 6.cxd5 exd5`
    - **Modern Variation** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...d5 6.cxd5 Nxd5`
    - **Kasparov Attack** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...d5 6.cxd5 Nxd5 7.Qc2`
    - **Petrosian Attack** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...d5 6.cxd5 Nxd5 7.e3`
    - **Polovodin Gambit** E12
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.Nc3 Bb7 5.a3 d5 6.cxd5 Nxd5 7.e4`

- **Rashkovsky Attack** E12
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...d5 6.cxd5 Nxd5 7.Qa4
- **Romanishin Attack** E12
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.a3 Bb7 5.Nc3 -> 5...d5 6.cxd5 Nxd5 7.Bd2
- **Capablanca Variation** E16
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Bb4
- **Spassky System3** E14
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.e3 Bb7 5.Bd3 c5
- **Traditional Variation** E17
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7
- **Anti-Queen's Indian System** E17
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.Nc3
- **Classical Variation** E17
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O
  - **Traditional Variation** E18
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O -> 6...O-O 7.Nc3
    - **Nimzowitsch Line** E18
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O O-O 7.Nc3 -> 7...d5
    - **Main Line** E19
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O O-O 7.Nc3 -> 7...Ne4 8.Qc2 Nxc3 9.Qxc3
  - **Tiviakov Defense** E18
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O -> 6...O-O 7.Nc3 Na6
  - **Polugaevsky Gambit** E17
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O -> 6...O-O 7.d5 exd5 8.Nh4
  - **Taimanov Gambit** E17
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O -> 6...O-O 7.d5 exd5 8.Nd4
- **Riumin Variation** E16
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Bb4 6.Bd2 Be7
- **Yates Variation** E16
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Bb4 4.Bd2 a5 5.g3 b6 6.Bg2 Bb7
- **Buerger Variation** E15
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 c5 6.d5 exd5 7.Ng5
- **Euwe Variation** E17
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.O-O O-O 7.b3
- **Opocensky Variation** E17
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7 6.Nc3 Ne4 7.Bd2
- **Averbakh Variation** E14
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 -> 4.e3 Bb7 5.Bd3 c5 6.O-O Be7 7.b3 O-O 8.Bb2 cxd4 9.Nxd4

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 b6 4.g3 Bb7 5.Bg2 Be7
```

Plan chain

White	d4 -> c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> g3
Black	Nf6 -> e6 -> Bb4 -> b6 -> Bb7

Three rules to remember

1. Control e4 with pieces, then break with ...d5 or ...c5.

2. White occupies the centre with e4 or plays a3/Bxc3 structures; Black strikes with ...d5/...c5 and piece pressure.

3. White wants the bishop pair and a big centre; Black wants to restrain e4 and hit the centre.

Pawn structure in one line

Black controls e4 with pieces (pin on c3 or Bb7) while White takes the c4/d4 centre or the bishop pair. Catalan: White uses g3/Bg2 pressure on d5 and the long diagonal.